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 By [Westpac New Zealand Economics](#)

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Middle East conflict presents two-sided risks for RBNZ

New hostilities in the Middle East, which have led to a sharp increase in the prices of crude oil and petroleum, have caused markets to worry about the potential for a protracted lift in inflation and tighter policy from the world’s inflation-targeting central banks. We think that such an outcome is less likely in New Zealand, where a starting point of spare capacity means less risk of second-round effects from a temporary rise in petrol prices. Indeed, given that starting point, it would be folly to entirely rule out scenarios that could lead to further policy easing. This might occur if the conflict led to a severe downward revision to the outlook for global growth and commodity prices, dampening New Zealand’s fledging recovery and posing downside risks to the medium-term inflation outlook. In the meantime, faced with two-sided uncertainty, we think that the RBNZ will become even more wedded to the “on hold” stance communicated at last month’s meeting.

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